proved effective in Tihar. Its long-term lessons have been positive in that reforms inside prisons are a safer route to take as opposed to leaving the prisoners to themselves. The ultimate success of such a correctional system would, of course, depend on the extension of such programmes to these groups. And surely the various reformative programmes have spread far and wide within India and overseas, thanks to the greater dissemination through technology.

However, the fact remains that though certain negative pressure groups will always be everywhere in a minority, yet they exercise the maximum disruptive influence. One of the main reasons for such influence – and what was seen to be the biggest problem in Tihar – was overcrowding. Interdepartmental coordination and cooperation could go a long way in checking the influx of prisoners to jail. Constructing new prisons and thus increasing the capacity was an obvious solution, which could prove to be a little misleading. Given the system that then prevailed, it would not appear far-fetched to see even the new prisons becoming overcrowded if certain changes were not made in the entire system. This would lead to the consideration of the *role of prisons in society*. We must come to the educated conclusion that only such people should be sent to prison who indulge in violence or activities dangerous to the well-being of society. There are innumerable deterrents that already exist in society and its institutions and more can be reasonably created wherein a person does not necessarily have to go to prison for any and all offences. It is only when these deterrents fail that imprisonment should be considered. Only in the case of such offences where it is felt that any other punishment would diminish the seriousness of the offence or crime committed should imprisonment be resorted to. For instance: where a life of crime has been deliberately chosen by the offender as his or her mode of existence and livelihood; or, where a person shows continued insensitivity to the other deterrents imposed upon him or her.

It is for society to reflect upon these issues and to devise a system wherein prison management is not isolated and where it can work in coordination with society and its other institutions which, in essence, have a common goal.

However, given the present system, the story of Tihar stands out as an outstanding example of what can be achieved by a sensitive, humane and benevolent leadership.